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Voter Information Guide

Virginia's April 21, 2026 Redistricting Amendment

Prepared for Richmond First members and followers

Nonpartisan background for an informed vote.

Executive Summary

Beginning March 6 through April 21, 2026, Virginians will vote on a **constitutional amendment** that would temporarily give the **General Assembly** the authority to redraw **congressional districts** for the 2026 and 2028 U.S. House elections. A **“Yes”** vote temporarily suspends Virginia’s bipartisan redistricting commission for congressional maps only. A **“No”** vote keeps the current court-drawn map in place. The proposal arises amid national mid-decade redistricting by several other states and is framed by supporters and opponents within that broader context.

Richmond First does **not** endorse a position. This guide summarizes facts, processes, and commonly cited arguments so voters may cast an informed vote.

1. What Is on the Ballot?

Beginning March 6 through April 21, 2026, Virginians will vote on a **constitutional amendment** that would:

- **Temporarily suspend** the use of Virginia’s bipartisan redistricting commission for **congressional maps only**.
- Give the **General Assembly (state legislators)** one-time authority to redraw Virginia’s **11 U.S. House districts** for the 2026 and 2028 elections.
- **Restore the commission** for congressional redistricting after the **2030 Census**.
- **Not change** how **state legislative districts** (House of Delegates and Senate) are drawn.

Ballot wording (summary):

Voters will be asked whether the constitution should be amended to **“restore fairness in the upcoming election”** by allowing the General Assembly to redraw congressional districts.

Note: This phrasing was adopted by the General Assembly. Supporters and opponents disagree on whether this wording is neutral. The legal effect of a “yes” vote is to temporarily return map-drawing power to the legislature for congressional districts.

2. How Are Congressional Districts Drawn Now?

The Current System (Since 2022)

- In 2020, Virginia voters approved a **bipartisan redistricting commission** through a constitutional amendment.
- After the 2020 Census, the commission **could not agree** on new congressional maps.
- Under the constitution, responsibility then shifted to the **Supreme Court of Virginia**, which:
 - Appointed **two outside experts**, one nominated by Democrats and one by Republicans.
 - Adopted maps intended to **reflect Virginia’s overall vote patterns** and not “unduly favor any party.”
- These congressional maps were first used in **2022** and produced a delegation of:
 - **6 Democrats**, and
 - **5 Republicans**.

Independent analysts such as the **Princeton Gerrymandering Project** graded the current congressional map as an **“A” for partisan fairness**, meaning it roughly tracks the statewide political balance.

3. What Would Change if the Amendment Passed?

If the amendment is **approved**:

- The **Democratic-controlled General Assembly** would implement a **new congressional map** (already drafted and made public).
- This map is designed so that:
 - **10 of the 11 districts** are expected to **lean Democratic**, and
 - **1 district** (in far Southwest Virginia) is expected to **lean Republican**.
- The new map would be used for the **2026 and 2028 U.S. House elections**.
- After the **2030 Census**, congressional redistricting authority would return to the **bipartisan commission / court fallback system**.

If the amendment is **rejected**:

- The existing **court-drawn congressional districts** remain in place for upcoming elections.
- There is **no temporary suspension** of the commission.
- The current constitutional framework continues unchanged.

4. Comparison of the Current and Proposed Maps

- **Overall Partisan Balance**

Under the **current map** (adopted for use beginning in 2022):

- The U.S. House delegation has been **6 Democrats and 5 Republicans**.

Under the **proposed map**:

- Analysts project that up to **10 districts** would be likely to elect **Democrats**, and
- **1 district** would likely elect a **Republican**, in a state that is competitive but leans Democratic overall.

Map Type	Democratic Seats	Republican Seats
Current Map	6	5
Proposed Map	10	1

Caption:

Figure 1. Comparison of the expected partisan balance under the current court-drawn map (6D–5R) and the proposed legislature-drawn map (up to 10D–1R), based on recent statewide election data.

- **Geographic and Population Shifts**

Under the **current map**:

- In general, **urban and suburban areas** (e.g., Northern Virginia, Richmond, Hampton Roads) are represented by **Democrats**.
- Many **rural areas** (e.g., the Shenandoah Valley, Northern Neck, Southwest Virginia) are represented by **Republicans**.

Under the **proposed map**:

- Approximately **48% of Virginians** would be moved into a **different congressional district**.
- Many **rural or small-town communities** would be paired with **large, Democratic-leaning population centers**.
- The goal of the map designers is to consolidate Democratic voting strength so that only **one district in far Southwest Virginia** is safely or strongly Republican.

Examples frequently discussed:

- Parts of the **Shenandoah Valley** would be divided among as many as **four different districts**.
- Localities such as **Danville** and **Mathews County** could be shifted from Republican-leaning districts into **Democratic-leaning districts** whose population cores are in **Richmond** or **Northern Virginia**.

Category	Approximate Percentage
Staying in Same District	52%
Moving to a Different District	48%

Caption:

Figure 2. Approximate share of Virginians who would remain in their current congressional district versus those who would be moved to a new district under the proposed map.

5. Why Is This Happening Now? National Context

Redistricting is normally done **once per decade** after the U.S. Census. The current proposal is part of a **mid-decade, multi-state struggle** over control of the U.S. House of Representatives.

- President **Donald Trump** urged several **Republican-controlled states** (e.g., **Texas, Missouri, North Carolina, Florida**) to redraw congressional maps mid-decade to increase the number of Republican seats.
- In response, some **Democratic-controlled states** (such as **California**, and now potentially **Virginia**) have considered or adopted redistricting changes to **offset these Republican gains**.
- National Democratic leaders have described the Virginia referendum as an important opportunity to **counterbalance Republican maps** in other states and have committed substantial funding to support the “**yes**” campaign.

Implications for Virginia:

- Virginia currently has a **court-drawn** congressional map graded highly for fairness.

Voters are being asked whether the **Commonwealth should adjust its redistricting approach** in response to changes in other states, including the possibility of **temporarily adopting** a map that differs from current political balances.

6. Common Arguments: In Favor and Against

Richmond First is providing this information **without endorsing either position**. The points below summarize arguments you are likely to hear from each side.

- **Arguments from Supporters of the Amendment (Vote “YES”)**

Supporters include:

- National Democratic leaders and organizations.
- The Virginia-based group **Virginians for Fair Elections**.
- Some Virginia officials and citizens previously supported the redistricting commission but now favor a temporary change.

Key arguments:

- **Countering National Gerrymandering**

Supporters argue that Republican-controlled states have already changed their maps to gain additional U.S. House seats. They contend that unless Democratic-leaning states respond, the **national balance of power** will not reflect overall voter preferences.

- **“Restoring Fairness” at the National Level**

Proponents say fairness should be considered across all states, not just within one. They see Virginia’s proposed change as a way to **offset imbalances** from other states’ partisan maps, rather than as an isolated power grab.

- **Voters Have the Final Say**

The proposed map has been **released in advance**, allowing voters to review it before the referendum. Supporters emphasize that voters can **approve or reject** this strategy directly at the ballot box.

- **Temporary and Limited Change**

The amendment does not abolish the commission. It would apply **only to congressional districts** and only until the **next Census-based redistricting in 2030**, after which the commission process resumes. Supporters describe it as a **one-time corrective**.

- **Arguments from Opponents of the Amendment (Vote “NO”)**

Opponents include:

- The bipartisan group **No Gerrymandering Virginia**.
- Many Virginia Republicans.
- A number of reform-minded Democrats and independents who supported the 2020 commission amendment.

Key arguments:

- **Protecting the Commission and Voter-Approved Reforms**

Opponents stress that Virginia voters only recently chose to establish an **independent redistricting commission** to reduce partisan gerrymandering. Temporarily suspending this system, even for a few years, is seen as undermining the **will of the voters** and weakening an important **constitutional safeguard**.

- **Concerns about an Extreme Partisan Map**

Moving from a delegation of **approximately 6 Democrats and 5 Republicans** to a projection of **10 Democrats and 1 Republican** in a still-competitive state is viewed as an **extreme gerrymander**, regardless of which party benefits. Opponents argue that this would leave many Republican-leaning voters with little realistic chance of electing their preferred representatives.

- **Loaded Ballot Language and Rushed Procedures**

Critics argue that wording the question as “restore fairness” is **biased** and likely to push voters toward a “yes” answer. They also raise concerns that the amendment process was **hurried** to place the measure on the ballot in time for an April 2026 vote, potentially sidestepping normal deliberative procedures.

- **Avoiding a Permanent National Arms Race**

Opponents worry that if more states, including Virginia, continually redraw lines mid-decade for partisan advantage, it will encourage **ongoing escalations** by both parties. They argue that **stable, neutral institutions** (commissions and court-drawn maps) provide better long-term protection for representative democracy.

7. Legal Uncertainty and the Role of the Courts

- The **Supreme Court of Virginia** allowed the **April 21 referendum** to proceed, but it is also considering a **lawsuit** (brought by Republican plaintiffs) challenging the legality of the amendment process.
- Several outcomes are possible:
 - **If voters reject the amendment:**
 - a) The lawsuit will likely be **moot**.
 - b) Future congressional elections will continue under the **current court-drawn map**.
 - **If voters approve the amendment and the Court upholds it:** The **proposed map** will be used for the **2026 and 2028** congressional elections.
 - **If voters approve the amendment but the Court finds legal flaws:**
 - a) The Court could **invalidate the amendment** or aspects of the process.

- b) This could raise difficult questions, such as whether to change maps again or, in an extreme case, whether to revisit the results of an election conducted under an invalidated map.
 - Because of this, the **final outcome may depend both on the voters and on the Court's interpretation** of the state constitution and redistricting procedures.
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8. How to See What Happens to Your Area

To understand how the amendment might affect you personally, you can explore **interactive, nonpartisan tools**.

- **Virginia Public Access Project (VPAP) – District Viewer**
 - Go to the VPAP website and open the **District Viewer** tool.
 - Enter your **home address** to see:
 - Your **current congressional district**, and
 - Your **proposed district** under the new map.
 - You can zoom out to see how districts shift around:
 - a) The **City of Richmond**,
 - b) **Henrico, Chesterfield, Hanover**, and surrounding localities,
 - c) Other regions across Virginia.
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9. Questions to Consider Before You Vote

As you review the information and examine the maps, you may find it useful to consider the following questions:

- **Process vs. Outcome**

Do you place more weight on:

 - **Preserving an independent process** (the commission and court oversight), or **Considering** whether Virginia should change its redistricting approach in response to actions taken in other states, even if that results in a temporary shift in the map's political balance?
- **Fairness Within Virginia vs. Nationally**

Should “fairness” be judged mainly:

 - **Within Virginia**, by asking whether our map reflects our statewide vote share and regional communities, or
 - **Nationally**, by looking at the overall balance of seats across many states and considering Virginia's role in offsetting partisan maps elsewhere?

- **Temporary Changes and Precedents**

Does the **temporary** nature of this amendment (limited to congressional maps, reverting after 2030) make it more acceptable to you, or do you see it as setting a **precedent** for future mid-decade changes by whichever party is in power?

- **Local Representation and Competitiveness**

Under the proposed map:

- Would your community likely be in a district that is **competitive** between the parties, or **safely** aligned with one party?
- How important is having **competitive elections** compared to having more **predictable partisan outcomes**?

10. Summary

- Virginia currently uses a **commission-plus-court** system for congressional redistricting, which produced a **broadly neutral map** with a **6 Democrat, 5 Republican** delegation and an “A” fairness grade from independent analysts.
- The April 21 amendment would **temporarily give the General Assembly authority** to implement a **new congressional map** likely to produce **up to 10 Democratic and 1 Republican seat** for at least the 2026 and 2028 elections.
- **Supporters** highlight the need to **counter partisan redistricting in other states, restore fairness nationally**, and stress that the change is **temporary** and decided directly by voters.
- **Opponents** emphasize the importance of **protecting the independent commission**, avoiding a **highly partisan redistricting**, preserving the integrity of the **state constitution**, and resisting a **national redistricting arms race**.
- The **Supreme Court of Virginia** may still influence the outcome after the vote by ruling on the legality of the amendment process.

Richmond First encourages all voters to:

- Review the **actual ballot language**,
- Study how the **proposed map** would affect your community using tools like VPAP’s District Viewer,
- Weigh the **arguments and principles** on both sides, and
- Participate in the **April 21, 2026 referendum** as an informed voter.

11. References: VPAP (Virginia Public Access Project) | Ballotpedia | Virginia Mercury